UNIT 12

Local Governments



Learning Objectives

- This chapter provides insights in to the local governments in India and as well as in Tamil Nadu state.
- It also provides the significance of local self government today
- This chapter would explain the scope of the Local Self government in the lives of the people today.
- This chapter would throws light on historical development and the major changes that have been made in powers and functions of local government since independence.
- Students would learn the structure, functions, elections, sources of revenue and issues in the rural and urban local governments in India.

12.1 Meaning, Nature and Importance of Local Government

Local Government means, the government which manages services and amenities in our villages, towns and cities with focus on local problems. The local governments normally functions within a specified limited territory of a village, a town, a city and also a large metropolitan city. The local governments function as the basic link between the people in a village or town with the government. As and when people have problems such as road repairs, water stagnation in the streets, non functioning of street lights and construction of small water bodies recreation parks, etc. The local governments have the responsibility to attend to any emergency situations, birth or death of persons in the village or town. The local governments are the institutions, which issues certificates of proof of residence, birth, death and incomes etc to the residents in that area. In total, the local governments are the institutions which are responsible for all such local needs of the people. They are the lowest unit of administration in the administrative structure of the government. The local government has council, which is normally elected by the people of the village or town concerned, which is responsible for the representing the problems of the citizens in the council and find solutions to the problems. The council representatives are elected once in five years, or four years, depending upon the law in operation in the country.



The local governments are representative institutions, representating people in the council. There are legally mandated to discuss and give solutions to the problems of the people of that area and also represent the problem to the higher levels of the government such as state. Since the local governments are established on the basis of democratic process, all the problems discussed by the council of the local governments should go through the process of discussion, debate and deliberations and unanimously accepted by the council. The members of

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